AxarquíaHome



2026-2027 EDITION

Checklist: renovating a house in the Axarquía

From plan to handover: permits, quotes, payments, renovating from abroad and what to check before the final payment.

Frigiliana

Welcome to the Axarquía

White villages against the mountains, terraces full of olive, almond and avocado trees, and a coastline of little coves beneath the cliffs. The Axarquía, east of Málaga, is one of the most beautiful places in Andalusia to live.

With around 300 days of sunshine a year, Málaga airport about an hour's drive away and villages such as Frigiliana, Cómpeta and Nerja, it is easy to see why so many Dutch, German, Swedish and British people have a home here. A house in this region does need the right approach, and that is what this checklist helps with.



Cómpeta and the Sierra Almijara



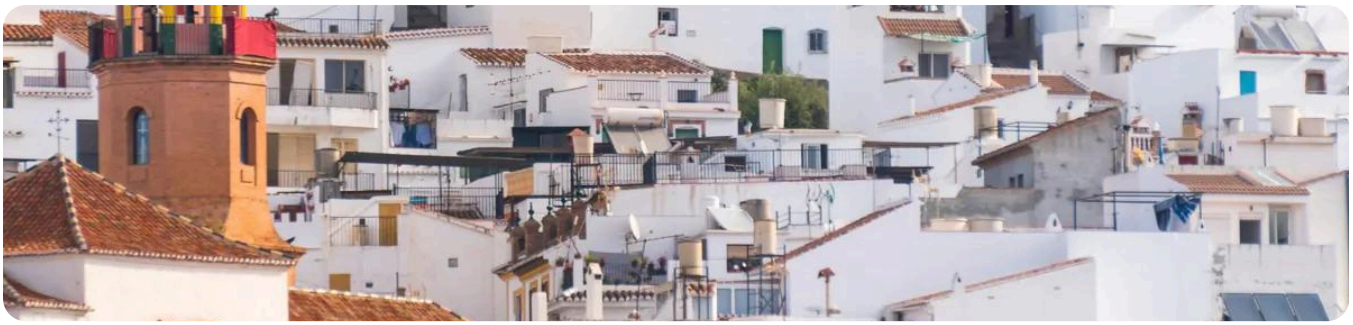
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Bougainvillea in Nerja

Renovating a house in the Axarquía is a wonderful project. An old village house or a finca full of character becomes a place you will enjoy for years. But renovating in Spain means different rules, different habits and often a lot of distance.

This checklist puts everything in order, in the sequence you will come across it, from the first plan to the handover. Tick off what is arranged and you avoid the best-known pitfalls: extra work without agreement, work without a permit and payments without an invoice.



Cómpeta

1. Plan and budget

The clearer you are about what you want, the easier it is to compare quotes.

- [ ] Wish list per room: what must be done, and what would be nice
- [ ] Budget set, with a 10 to 15% buffer for what turns up during demolition
- [ ] Rough price per m²: refresh €250 – €500, mid-size €600 – €1,000, full renovation €1,000 – €1,600
- [ ] Condition known: roof, damp, electrics, pipes and structure
- [ ] Order decided: roof, damp and pipes first, finishing last
- [ ] Timing matched to the seasons: roof and outside work ideally before the autumn rain
- [ ] Thought about the future: step-free living, insulation, air conditioning or heat pump, solar panels
- [ ] For a larger plan: a floor plan or 3D design, so you can see the choices before you start

What often only shows during demolition

Damp behind the skirting, mould and old or missing insulation: in old houses it often only appears once the tiles come off. That is why you need the buffer.



Black mould spots at the bottom of a white interior wall, just above the skirting board



Mineral wool insulation being laid between timber joists by hands in work gloves



Frigiliana

2. Permits and rules

Work without notification or permit causes problems when you sell. Arrange it first.

- [ ] Checked whether the work needs a notification (declaración responsable) or a permit (licencia de obra)
- [ ] For a permit: architect and arquitecto técnico chosen and the project drawn up
- [ ] Building tax (ICIO, 2 to 4% of the building cost in the Axarquía) and fees in the budget
- [ ] For a house on rural land: checked what is allowed; extending is often not
- [ ] For a house with AFO status: only maintenance and renovation within the existing size
- [ ] Work started only once the permit is granted or the notification filed
- [ ] An old corrugated roof (uralita) often contains asbestos: removal only by a licensed company
- [ ] New square metres added to the cadastre (Catastro) afterwards



Canillas de Albaida

3. Quotes and choosing a builder

Ask for two or three quotes based on the same description.

- [ ] Quote (presupuesto) broken down per item (partida), with what is and is not included
- [ ] IVA shown separately: 10% for renovating a home for own use, otherwise 21%
- [ ] Clear whether waste removal, permit and ICIO are included
- [ ] Builder has a tax number (CIF or NIF) and liability insurance
- [ ] References or earlier projects seen, ideally nearby
- [ ] Schedule with start and end dates in writing
- [ ] Agreed that extra work is only done in writing and after your approval
- [ ] One fixed contact person who speaks your language



Nerja

4. Payments and paperwork

Pay per completed stage, always by bank transfer and against an invoice.

- [ ] Payment schedule agreed: 20 to 30% at the start, then per stage
- [ ] 5 to 10% held back until after handover and the last snags are fixed
- [ ] Every invoice in your name and NIE number, with IVA and the builder’s tax number
- [ ] Never in cash: from €1,000 (non-residents €10,000) it is illegal, and you lose your guarantee
- [ ] All invoices kept: when you sell, they reduce the gain you pay tax on
- [ ] Extra work confirmed with a price by WhatsApp or email before it is done



The valley below Canillas de Albaida

5. Renovating from abroad

Not living in Spain? This is how you stay in control without flying out every week.

- [ ] Weekly update with photos or video agreed
- [ ] One group chat with the builder and, if any, the architect
- [ ] A payment made only after you have seen photos of the work it covers
- [ ] Keys and access arranged: who lets in tradespeople and suppliers?
- [ ] Power of attorney (poder notarial) for a gestor if signatures are needed
- [ ] Material and colour choices fixed in advance, with photos and product codes
- [ ] Visits planned for the key moments: after demolition and at handover

6. Handover

- [ ] Walked through the house with the builder, with a list of snags
- [ ] Drains, taps, windows and doors tested; roof terrace checked after heavy rain
- [ ] Electrical certificate (boletín) received if the electrics were renewed
- [ ] Guarantees and manuals for boiler, air conditioning, pump and appliances received
- [ ] With a permit: completion certificate (certificado final de obra) and notification to the town hall
- [ ] Final payment made only once all snags are fixed
- [ ] Arranged who keeps an eye on the house for the first months: small leaks are best caught early



Frigiliana

7. Questions to ask

The builder

1. What is and is not included in the price?
2. Who is my contact on site, and in which language?
3. When do you start, and when will you finish?
4. What happens if something turns up during demolition?
5. How do you report extra work, and when do I decide?
6. Do you work with your own people or subcontractors?
7. Are you insured for damage to the house or the neighbours?
8. Who handles the notification or permit?
9. What guarantee do you give, and for how long?
10. Can I see projects you have done before?

The architect or town hall

1. Is a notification enough for this work, or do I need a permit?
2. How long does the permit take, and what does the project cost?
3. How high are the ICIO and fees in this municipality?
4. What is allowed on this land, and can I extend?
5. Does what stands now match the cadastre?
6. Is there asbestos in the roof or old pipes?
7. What rules apply to insulation and energy?
8. Do I qualify for a grant for making the house more sustainable?
9. What do I have to report or register afterwards?
10. Who supervises the work during construction?

8. Worksheet: what will the renovation cost?

Fill in the amounts from the quotes. That shows you the total, including everything that is often added.

Builder's price (excl. IVA)		€
IVA	10% or 21%	€
Architect and arquitecto técnico	with a permit	€
ICIO and fees	2 – 4% of building cost	€
Waste removal and skip		€
Kitchen, bathroom fittings and appliances (if bought separately)		€
Air conditioning, heat pump or solar panels		€
Contingency	10 – 15%	€
Travel and stays during visits		€
Furnishing and cleaning after the work		€
Total		**€**

Keep all invoices. When you sell, they reduce the gain you pay tax on in Spain.



Planning a renovation?

Tell us what you have in mind. Our building partner in the Axarquía comes to look, gives you a quote per item and, if needed, arranges the architect and the permit. While the work is going on, you get photos every week.

Request a quote

axarquiahome.com/en/request/ · info@axarquiahome.com

This checklist gives general information and is not legal or tax advice. Rules and rates differ per municipality. Amounts are indicative (2026).